

THE SHORT LEDGER

Fourth Wall Gaming

PRELUDE

Purewater is built on water and admits it.

There is no ground and there are no roads. Houses come straight up out of the channel with no bank and no shore, and the doors open onto steps that go down under the surface. What traffic matters goes by boat. The rest goes over a bridge or along a ledge a yard wide with no rail, and everything costs a fare.

Anybody raised in that city can handle a boat. It is like walking. The other half of that, which nobody in Purewater ever bothers to say out loud, is that nobody else can — and so a stranger in this city cannot move a sack of flour across it without hiring somebody who was born here.

There are no horses either. The land stops at Caravan Square. A column coming down the Anminster road gets as far as the gate and then has to be put in boats in public, one piece at a time.

The Lake Lady's Tourney comes once a year — archery, single combat, and a scramble across the canals — and for the week of it the city fills up and the law goes quiet.

This year Baron Hanzo di Teufel came for it, with Dragon Knights, and a champion nobody had been allowed to see.

None of that is what this book is about.

It is about a half-orc who did collections on the Shoals bridges, and who found three accounts short in one week for one reason, and who went and looked.

CHAPTER 1 — THE SHORT LEDGER



The bridges of the Shoals paid on the third day of the week and they paid in the morning, before the catch was sorted and while the money was still loose on the trestles. Kag walked them in order, north to south, and she had walked them in that order for nine years.

She was seven feet of her and the fish market moved around her without being asked to.

At the rope stall the man was eleven shillings short. His name was Dess and he sold cordage on the third pitch along and he had never been short before in four years.

"I'll have it Thursday," Dess said.

"You'll have it Thursday."

"I will."

She wrote the eleven in the book and she wrote Thursday beside it and she went on to the next.

The next was short as well. Six shillings, off a woman who sold ice by the sack and had a boy to help her lift, and the boy was not there. Two pitches on from her a man who dealt in cheap brass was short by nine.

Kag stopped in the middle of the bridge and got the book out again and stood there with it.

Three in a row was not three men stealing. Three men stealing did not steal in a line.

She went back to the ice woman.

“Where’s the boy?”

“He’s about.”

“He’s not about. Where’s the boy.”

The woman looked down the bridge and then she looked at her hands.

“They took the barrow,” she said. “Two of them, Monday. They wanted the ice for the horses and they took the barrow to carry it and they didn’t bring the barrow back.”

“Did they pay?”

“They don’t pay.”

“Did anybody give you a chit.”

“There’s no chit. There’s nobody to give a chit. You go and ask them for a chit.”

Kag went back to Dess.

“Sixty feet,” Dess said. “Off the end of the rack. Best line I had. Four of them and they didn’t hurry.”

“Who’d you bill?”

Dess laughed. It was not much of a laugh and it stopped before it was finished.

*
**

She did the arithmetic on the steps at the south end where the stone was dry.

Eleven and six and nine was twenty-six shillings off one bridge in one week. There were nine bridges on the Shoals and eleven on the Lullwater and she had walked all of them and she knew what each one paid in an ordinary month.

Twenty-six became eleven pounds by Michaelmas if nobody stopped it. It became more than that, because a man who cannot pay stops asking for credit, and a man who stops asking for credit stops buying, and then the stall goes and then the pitch goes.

She wrote that down too. It took her half a page and she used a fresh leaf for it because the sums wanted room.

A gull got into somebody's basket further up and there was shouting.

*
**

Crowbill kept a counting room over a chandler's and he was in it and he had the shutters open.

He read the page standing up. He read all of it, to the bottom, and he did not say anything while he was reading and he did not say anything for a while after.

"Twenty-six," he said.

"Off one bridge. This week."

"It's not skimming."

"No."

"Say it, then."

"They're not short because they're keeping it," Kag said. "They're short because there's four hundred armed men in this city taking what they like off the stalls, and there's nobody in the whole household to present a bill to, and every man on that bridge has worked that out and none of them have said it out loud."

Crowbill turned the page over and looked at the back of it, which was blank, and turned it again.

"Nine weeks," he said. "Nine weeks they've been here and not one bill."

"Not one."

"Who have you told."

“You.”

He put the page down on the ledge by the shutter and put a stone on it, out of a habit he had from when the shutters were open and the wind came up off the Mouth.

“Cost it by the day,” he said. “The whole city, not your bridges. I’ll want it by Friday.”

“You’ve got two men who do that.”

“I’ve got two men who count. That’s not the same thing and you know it’s not, and that’s why I’m asking you and not them.”

She did not say anything.

“Go on,” Crowbill said. “And Kag. Don’t do anything about it.”

*
**

She did something about it at four in the afternoon.

There were four of them at the Fishmarket end and they were taking fish. Not buying it and not asking for it. One of them had a sack and the other three stood in a line across the width of the bridge so that the traffic had to go round, which on a bridge means it does not go at all.

They were in di Teufel green and they were young and they were bored.

The woman whose fish it was said nothing. Forty people said nothing. That was the part of it Kag would remember afterwards, that there were forty people on that bridge and the only sound was the sack.

“That’s stealing,” Kag said.

The one with the sack looked up.

“What.”

“What you’re doing. There’s a word for it and the word is stealing. You take a thing and you don’t pay and you don’t leave a chit and there’s nobody to bill. That’s not requisition. Requisition has paper.”

“Get out of the road.”

“She’s got four children and she buys that fish at three in the morning off a boat that wants cash,” Kag said. “And you’ll eat it tonight and you’ll not think about it again, and that’s fine, that’s soldiering. But don’t call it anything else. You’re thieves.”

Nobody moved.

The young one with the sack went red in the neck and started to say something and the oldest of the four put a hand flat on his chest without looking at him.

“Move along, then,” the oldest one said.

Kag moved along. She went up the steps at the south end and she did not hurry and she did not look back, and behind her the bridge stayed quiet for about four seconds and then all forty of them started talking at once.

She was on the third step when she heard the laugh come.

By dusk it had got to the Lullwater. By the next morning she had been eight feet tall in it and there had been six of them.

CHAPTER 2 — WHO MENDED HER



The girl was carved at the Sylph's Embrace in the small hours and by seven in the morning it was the only thing anybody on the water would talk about.

Kag got it four times before eight and it was different every time. A man had come in off a boat. A man had come down from the Vantt. There had been three of them. There had been one. The girl was dead. The girl was not dead. The girl was an elf and the finest performer on the Pearl and a man had opened her up the length of her body with a knife and gone out of a first-floor window.

The Watch had been and the Watch had written it down and the Watch had gone away again.

Everybody was asking who did it.

Kag sat on the ice-house step with a bowl and thought about that for a while and then she sent for Pell.

*
**

Pell was eleven and he ran messages for a copper and he had feet like a man of forty. He came at a run with his shirt half off his shoulder and stood in front of her breathing.

"You want me to find out who cut her," Pell said.

"No."

He waited.

"Everybody on this water is asking who cut her," Kag said. "Forty people are asking it and they'll all get told the same three lies by dinner. I don't want that."

"What, then."

"Go to the Pearl. Go in the tradesmen's door at Constantine's and ask the cook, and if the cook won't have you ask whoever's washing. And what you ask them is this. Who mended her."

Pell looked at her.

"Say it back."

"Who mended her."

"Not who cut her."

"Who mended her."

"That's the whole of it. Don't ask anything else. Don't tell them who sent you unless they ask twice, and if they ask twice tell them, because it's a house and they'll find out anyway."

"Why that one."

"Because a girl cut like that bleeds out before dawn," Kag said. "And it's eight in the morning and she's alive. So somebody in that house did something in the dark that a surgeon couldn't do, and whoever that is is the only person in this city who was in the room."

Pell was already going.

"Eat something first," Kag said, and he came back for the bowl and took it with him.

**

He was back at eleven and he had it.

"There's an elf-girl," he said. "She come in Monday off the road with an old woman and the both of them took work for the week, the old one on the door and the elf on the water-stair. And when the

screaming started the elf went up, and the cook says she was up there an hour with her hands on her and the girl stopped dying.”

“What’s her name.”

“Gardwen. She’s got a wolf.”

“She’s got a what.”

“A wolf. It lies on the landing and it doesn’t let anybody past and Constantine’s let it stay.” Pell was pleased with this part. “And the cook says the elf hasn’t left the room since. Not to eat, not for anything. Three days.”

“Three days is two days.”

“Two days, then.”

Kag put the book on her knee and wrote *Gardwen — elf — wolf — water-stair — was in the room.*

“And the old woman.”

“Magda. She’s on the front door and she was on it that night.” Pell wiped his nose. “Cook says the man went out the window rather than come past her, and the cook says that’s the most sense he showed all night.”

*
**

She went up to the Pearl at noon and did not go in.

She stood on the quay opposite with a bowl of something and looked at the green shutters for the better part of an hour. The island was quiet. It was quiet at noon anyway, because the Pearl slept in the day, but it was the other kind of quiet as well, the kind where there are people behind every shutter and none of them are moving.

Two of Marisette’s men were on the step at Constantine’s and they were not pretending to be anything else.

A girl came out at one o’clock with a basket of linen and went down the water-stair and came back up without the basket, and she was

about thirteen and she was an elf, and she sat down on the step where she could see the front door and stayed there.

Kag watched her sit for twenty minutes. The girl did not read and did not eat and did not talk to the men on the step. She watched the door.

Then Kag finished the bowl and went back to the boats, because she had a camp to count and it was a long way east and she wanted the tide.

She did not go in and ask the elf-girl anything that day, and she thought about that afterwards more than once.

CHAPTER 3 — TWENTY-FIVE TENTS



There are no roads in Purewater and there are no horses. The land stops at Caravan Square and everything past it goes on the water, and everything the city eats comes down the Anminster road to the Gate of Triumph and gets put in a boat.

The di Teufel company had four hundred men in it, or it was said to have four hundred men in it, and four hundred men and their horses cannot be in a canal city. So they were east, on the Vantt estate, on dry ground, and nobody from the city went out there and nobody from out there came in except in twos and threes.

Kag went out under a water butt.

*
**

The barge was Sim's and it ran produce east three mornings a week and it had run produce east three mornings a week since before Kag was born. The butt was empty and on its side in the bow with sacking over it and it had a gap at the bung end you could get an eye to.

She got in at four and Sim put the sacking over and poled off and did not say anything about the weight.

It took two hours. She lay on her side on the boards with her knees up and her cheek on her arm and watched a strip of sky go past, and when the sky went from grey to the other grey she knew they were out of the city.

"Coming up on it," Sim said, to nobody, the way a man talks to a boat.

*
**

What she could see through a bunghole was a strip about two feet high, and the barge went past the landing at a walking pace, and it took a little over four minutes.

She counted tents.

There were twenty-five. She counted them twice and got twenty-five both times and then the angle closed and she could not count any more.

Eleven of them had no smoke.

It was a cold morning and every fire in Purewater was lit and there was not a chimney on the Shoals that was not going, and eleven tents on that meadow had nothing coming off them at all. A tent with no fire on a cold morning is a tent with nobody in it.

She counted horses in the lines and got forty-one and was not sure of forty-one, so she wrote forty and a question mark.

There were two wagons and one of them had a wheel off and had had the wheel off long enough for the grass to come up round the axle.

*
**

Sim tied at the estate landing and unloaded for an hour and Kag lay in the butt and listened.

Two of them came down to the landing while the sacks were going off. They were soldiers and they were talking about bread.

"He says Thursday."

"He said Thursday last Thursday."

"Then it's Thursday."

"There's no flour out here and there's flour eleven miles that way and no bugger will sell it to us."

“They’ll sell it to you.”

“They will not. I stood in the Fishmarket for an hour on Monday with money in my hand.”

They went away up the path. Somebody was hammering at the far end and stopped and started again.

Kag lay with her cheek on her arm and did the sum.

Twenty-five tents. Eleven of them cold. Call it fourteen tents live and call it eight men to a tent, which is generous for a tent, and you have a hundred and twelve. Call it ten to a tent and you have a hundred and forty. Forty-one horses, which is a horse for every third man and not a horse for every man, so it is not cavalry, it is a company with some riders in it.

Not four hundred. Nothing like four hundred.

Four hundred was a thing that had been said in the city and repeated in the city and nobody in the city had ever counted, because there was no way to count it, because there are no roads and nobody goes east.

The whole occupation was twenty-five tents and a story.

*
**

Coming back she heard the other thing.

Sim brought the barge in at the Guild landing at ten and there were three watermen on the stones and they were not working.

“Four o’clock this morning,” one of them said. “Off this landing. Tam and the Mendick boy.”

“Took where.”

“Took. Two of them come down and told them there was a fare and they got in and they’ve not come back, and Tam’s wife has been on this landing since six.”

“Whose boat.”

“Theirs. The green.”

Kag came out from under the sacking and stood up in the bow and the three of them looked at her and none of them were surprised, because it had been a morning for things.

“What time exactly,” she said.

“Four.”

“How do you know it was four.”

“Because the ice run goes out over the bar at four and Tam waved at it.”

She wrote that down. *Tam. Mendick boy. Guild landing. 4 a.m. Green boat. Waved at the ice.*

An hour before that, a man had come up this water soaked to the neck and poled east past two of the whiting boats in the dark, and one of the whiting men had said so to his wife and his wife had said it to the fish market, and by the time it got to Kag it was a ghost.

Outsiders cannot handle a boat. That was the thing about this city that everybody in it knew and nobody ever said, because it was like saying that water was wet. Hanzo di Teufel had come down the Anminster road with a column, and the road had stopped at the gate, and from the gate onward every single thing he did had to be done by somebody local.

So he had taken two.

Kag sat down on the gunwale and looked at the green boat's empty place on the landing for a while.

Then she went to find out what Marisette knew.

CHAPTER 4 — THE MOTHER OF PEARL



Marisette kept eleven houses and did not own one of them and every proprietor on that island answered to her. She saw Kag at dusk in an upstairs room with one window open onto the water, and she stayed sitting while Kag stood, which she did with everybody.

Kag put it on the table. Twenty-five tents. Eleven cold. Forty-one horses and a wagon with the grass grown up round the axle. No quartermaster. Nine weeks and not one bill presented anywhere in the city.

Marisette let all of it come out and did not write any of it down.

“And what do you want,” she said.

“Nothing.”

“Everybody wants something.”

“I’ve been asked for a number and I got a better one than I was asked for,” Kag said. “You’ll hear it inside a week off somebody who’ll charge you. You can have it now off me for nothing.”

“Whose instruction is that.”

“Crowbill’s.”

The lamp was on the low table between them and Marisette moved it about an inch, which put the light on both of their faces instead of one.

"No it isn't," she said.

Kag did not say anything.

"Sit down," Marisette said.

*
**

She sat, which put her eyes about level with the madame's.

"He didn't tell you to bring me that. He told you to cost the city and he told you not to do anything about it, and you have been doing something about it since Tuesday morning." Marisette poured two glasses and did not push either of them anywhere. "I have run this island for twenty-two years on knowing which of my girls is lying to me and why. You are very bad at it and the reason you are very bad at it is that you don't do it much."

"No."

"No." Marisette drank. "Why bring it to me."

"Because eleven houses shut is the largest thing that's happened in this city this week and it hasn't happened yet," Kag said. "And when it happens I'd like you to already know what he's actually got out there, because everybody else is going to tell you four hundred."

Marisette put the glass down.

"There is a man in a cellar under this building," she said.

*
**

He was a Sword of the Lake and his name was Sten and he had been in the cellar since Tuesday afternoon, and the reason he was in the cellar was that he had a beard and a coat and had been seen on Pearl Quay on the wrong night.

"He's not your man," Kag said.

"You've not seen him."

"I don't need to. Whoever went out that window was a client, in the house, paid for the evening, in the room. He wasn't on the quay.

He was upstairs, and he took a room, and there'll be a name in the book for the room and it won't be his own." Kag turned her hands over. "Your man in the cellar came to the quay after the screaming started. Everybody came to the quay after the screaming started. That's what a quay is for."

Marisette looked at the table.

"Bring him up," she said, to the girl on the stairs.

*
**

They gave Sten his falchion back at the water door and he stood there a while and then he thanked Kag, which she had not expected, and then he went and sat down on the steps because his legs were not good.

Kag went up to Constantine's afterwards and Constantine let her in because Marisette had sent word.

The room was on the third floor and it was shut up and it had not been cleaned, because nobody cleans a room while a girl is dying in the next one.

She did not touch anything for the first ten minutes. She got down on the boards with the lamp on the floor and looked along them, and then she moved the armoire out from the wall with her shoulder and put it back.

The knife was against the skirting where it had gone.

It was about eleven inches and it was not a weapon. The back edge was barbed the whole length of it, small swept-back hooks like fish-hooks, which are for opening a thing slowly and holding it open while you work. There was a groove down the flat. The grip was wound with something dark that was not leather.

There was a mark set into the pommel. A ring with a line through it and three strokes off the line. It had been cut small and it had been cut beautifully by somebody who had been paid properly for it.

Kag did not pick it up.

She got down with her cheek near the floor and turned it a quarter-turn with the back of her own knife, so the pommel came into the lamplight, and then she took a leaf off the back of Constantine's ledger and a stub of charcoal and took a rubbing.

It took four goes because the boards were not flat. The fourth one came out clean.

"You'll want the grate," Constantine said from the door.

*
**

There were three pieces in the grate and they came up in three pieces and a great deal of black that went to nothing between the fingers.

What survived was the middle. Two palm-sized pieces of heavy paper scorched brown at the margins and cream in the centre, and a third the size of a playing card. There was writing on them. Not printing. A dense sloping hand in brown ink with the letters run together, and in among the lines were figures drawn small and exact, and one of the figures was a ring with a line through it and three strokes off the line, twice over.

The paper was warm. There was no fire in the grate and had not been for two days.

"Whose hand," Constantine said.

"Not his."

"Not whose."

"Not a nineteen-year-old's," Kag said. "That's a man who's written this sort of thing a lot of times and doesn't have to think about the shape of the letters. That's fifty years of holding a pen."

Constantine went to the washstand and came back with a pen and ink and the house ledger, the real one, the one she did standing up, and opened it on the bed and started writing fast in a clear round hand.

"Half three or thereabouts," she said, out loud, as she went. "Twenty-first. The knife where it lies, behind the armoire, against the

skirting, not moved. The paper out of the grate, three pieces, taken by—”

She stopped.

“Kag.”

“Kag what.”

“Kag of no house,” Kag said. “It’s the only one I’ve got.”

Constantine wrote it and dated it and blotted it with the heel of her hand.

“Come back in daylight and I’ll countersign the paper,” she said.

Kag went down the stairs past a landing with a wolf on it. The wolf lifted her head and looked at her and put it down again.

In the boat going south she had a rubbing of a mark, three pieces of a working in a stranger’s hand, and one fact that was worth more than either of them.

It came in with them. And somebody in this city had made it to order.

Which meant a workshop. A drawing handed over a counter. A price paid, and a man who took it.

CHAPTER 5 — THE FOURTH OF JUNE



The Forge Quarter starts before the sun does.

It is High Isle's eastern point and it is hammers, a dozen of them going at different speeds out of different sheds, and under that the bellows-roar and the shriek of something being drawn. Coal smoke and hot iron and quench-water, and from the tanneries at the north end a thing that gets into the back of the throat and stays. Grit on everything. It is the only quarter in Purewater where the water runs black and the dwarves who run half of it have been complaining about that for two hundred years.

Kag took a bench outside a cookshop at six with a view of three sheds and a bowl, and sent Pell in with the rubbing.

He was good at it. He went in with his hands empty and said it the same way every time — *Kag'd like to know who cut this, please* — and showed the slip and did not touch anything. Three men sent him away. The fourth did not.

*
**

The fourth was a shed at the end of the founders' lane on the water. Orsk & Daughter, cutters and engravers. Four generations of it.

Old Orsk was seventy and did not come out from the back any more. It was the daughter who came to the door with the rubbing in

her hand, held up close to her eyes, and she was fifty-odd and had arms like a cooper's and she was not pleased.

Her name was Hild.

She looked down the lane and found Kag on the bench and jerked her head, which meant come.

"Where's the knife," Hild said.

"On a floor."

"Whose floor."

"A girl at the Sylph's Embrace. He opened her from the collarbone to the hip with it and went out of a window."

Hild stood in her own doorway with the slip in her fingers and did not say anything for a bit.

"Girl live?"

"She lived."

"Right." Hild turned the slip over. "Then you can have it."

*
**

She did not hand it over straight away. She went to the ledger first.

It was a proper one, chained to the bench, and it had four generations in it, and she ran a finger down a column and her face changed.

"I said nine weeks," she said. "That's wrong. I was going off the job and not off the book."

She turned the ledger round so Kag could see it and tapped the line.

4 June. Mark cut to drawing, pommel, fine. 2s 6d. Paid whole.

"Four months back," Hild said.

Kag looked at the date for a while.

The di Teufel column had come down the Anminster road nine weeks ago with four hundred men and every bell in three villages

going. The mark on that pommel had been cut in this shed four months before that.

"Tell me about him," Kag said.

"Purewater man. Fifty-five or thereabouts. Ink on the middle finger, not the first, which is a man who's held a pen fifty years." Hild shut the ledger. "Paid cash. In forty years I've had maybe three men pay cash for engraving."

"What did he look like."

"He'd cut the buttons off his coat."

"He'd what."

"Cut them off. Both rows. There was thread where they'd been and he'd not tidied it." Hild put her hands flat on the bench. "I thought he'd fallen on hard times and was ashamed of it, and I was sorry for him, and I did him a good job for two and six."

She looked up.

"He was frightened the whole time he was in this shed."

*
**

The Pearl went dark at ten that morning.

Marisette shut all eleven houses and she did it in one hour and she did not explain it to anybody, and by noon it was the only thing anybody in Purewater was talking about and the Fishmarket bridge was carrying ten times its usual traffic because half the island had nowhere to be.

Kag costed it on the ice-house step before the bells had finished.

Eleven houses. Four hundred and eleven people on that island who worked in them or off them — the girls, the cooks, the linen women, the boatmen who did nothing but the Pearl run, the boy who did the lamps, the four fiddlers, the woman who sold hot ones on the quay at two in the morning to people coming out. Four hundred and eleven, and she knew the number because she had the Pearl's traffic in the

back of her book for five years and she had never once had a reason to add it up before.

A day of it was a hundred and thirty pounds off the island. A week of it was what the whole occupation had cost the Shoals since the column came down the road.

She brought it to Crowbill and he read it standing up and then he sat down, which he did not do.

“That’s more in a night than they’ve cost me all week,” he said.

“Yes.”

“So what’s the answer.”

“You know the answer.”

“Say it anyway.”

“The answer is you go to the Baron with a purse and you settle,” Kag said. “You pay him to keep his boys off the stalls and you pay Marisette’s losses for a fortnight out of the same purse, and the island opens tomorrow and everything in my book comes right inside a month. That’s the arithmetic. I did it twice.”

Crowbill waited.

“And I’ll not do it,” Kag said.

“No?”

“He hasn’t got four hundred men. He’s got twenty-five tents and eleven of them are cold and he can’t move a sack of flour in this city without hiring a Purewater man to do it. He’s not an army sat on us. He’s a bluff, and the price of a bluff goes up every single time somebody pays it, and if you pay this one you’ll be paying the next one at Michaelmas and the one after at Candlemas, and by the spring this isn’t your city.”

She shut the book.

“You asked me for a number. That’s the number. The number says settle. I’m telling you the number’s wrong and I’m telling you why,

and that's the whole of what you pay me for and you've never once let me do it before today."

Crowbill sat for a long while.

Then he got up and opened a drawer that Kag had never seen open and took out a slate with names on it.

"Right," he said. "Then you'd better know what I've got."

He set one price, at the end of it, and it was the only one.

"The twenty-five stays in this yard. Not on a bridge. Not to Marisette. Not to a Sword of the Lake with a nice face. The day that gets out is the day they find out we've counted them, and then they have to either go or make it true, and neither of those is a thing I want happening on a Thursday."

*
**

The presentation of the entrants was that afternoon on the competitors' ground and half the city half-watched it.

Every entrant goes bare-headed in front of the Crown's representative for the space of a bow. It is ceremony and it is boring and the Baron could not avoid it without forfeiting his entry.

So the champion came out in harness with the rest of them and the helm came off for about four seconds.

He was seventeen. He was too thin for the armour he was in and he had the white skin of a thing kept somewhere without light, and he stood in daylight in front of several hundred people and he did not blink.

Thirty yards away on the ground an elf-woman with a wolf at her heel made a sound Kag heard over the top of four hundred other people.

Kag got to her before Magda did.

"That's my brother," Gardwen said.

"How long."

“Ten years. They took him at seven.” She was not crying and her hands were shaking and she had hold of the rail. “He’s been thirty yards from me since Monday.”

“What do you want.”

Gardwen said what she wanted. She wanted the Baron’s son, taken, held, and traded.

“No,” Kag said.

“Then—”

“No, and I’ll tell you why, and then I’ll tell you what I’ll do instead.” Kag put her back against the rail so she was looking the other way, at the crowd, which is how you talk to somebody on a ground with four hundred people on it. “You take a lordling as a hostage and you have started a war, and the war happens on the Shoals and on the Lullwater and in the low canals where four thousand people live on planks, and none of them have ever heard your brother’s name.”

“That’s your answer.”

“That’s the cost, and you asked me the wrong question. Here’s mine.” Kag looked at the ground. “I’ll bring your brother to Crowbill. Not the lordling. Him. And Crowbill can hide a thing in this city that a Baron cannot find with four hundred men, and he has been doing it since before you were born.”

Gardwen looked at her for a long moment.

“Nobody in this city has offered me anything,” she said.

“Nobody in this city has asked you a question either,” Kag said. “I’m asking. What does he answer to.”

And Gardwen told her his name, which was the first time Kag had heard it.

CHAPTER 6 — A LETTER IN HER OWN HAND



The chandler rendered tallow under Kag's room and the smell came up through the boards, and under it the Shoals had been awake since three. Winches. A man counting ice in Ostish. Gulls going at something on the roof opposite.

Pell sat on the end of the bed with his hands in the seam of her boot where the stitching had gone.

She told him what the day was and he stopped at the word.

"Bamboozle."

"Bamboozle."

He liked it. Then he let go of the boot.

"He can't pole," Pell said.

"Who can't."

"Blau's lad. The one that runs to the ship. He goes all the way round by the Fishmarket and the little humpback because there's no bridge at the ice-houses, and he won't get in a boat with anybody." Pell was pleased. "Near an hour each way. Twice before noon."

"How do you lose him."

"Ice. They break it into the channel at the humpback and it sets across when the tide's slack, and a boy who won't get in a boat stands and looks at it." He wiped his nose. "Or Mother Ives is out of the hot

ones. Then he's off to the Fishmarket and that's another quarter hour of his life."

Kag put her boots on.

"He's not been going to the ship," Pell said.

"Say that again."

"Two runs to the Long Butts yesterday and one out to the Vantt. They're dressing the box. Gerda's boy carried the chairs out and got a copper for it, and he says there's six."

*
**

The Long Butts before sunrise was two hundred paces of nothing.

Rope. Pegs. A man walking the line barefoot with a bucket of whitening, swearing at the wind. The wind came off the open water across the range instead of along it and it had been doing that since before light and it was the only thing anybody said all morning.

The stands were half built with the carpenters still on them. At the near end the Governor's box was dressed in green already. The one going up beside it was black, two men on a trestle, six chairs stacked on the grass waiting to go in.

Behind everything, the slope. And where the slope ran out at the west end, the landing. One stone quay, nine steps, a bollard line, four skiffs tied and dripping.

It was the only way off that shore onto the water.

By dusk two hundred people would want it at the same moment.

Kag stood on the grass and looked at it for a while and Pell got up on a bollard to see further and held his shirt down with both hands.

*
**

Marisette had the comb out already.

It was in a lacquer dish on a low table in her own room with the window open onto the water, and it had been there long enough to have dust on the teeth. Silver. A hair-comb.

She turned the dish a quarter turn so it faced Kag and left it on the table.

"I took that out of her things on Wednesday." A breath. "It's yours. The paper isn't mine to give."

Down on the quay a man was mending a rail and stopped hammering and started again.

"She's awake and she's upstairs at Constantine's with the elf-girl who won't leave the room. Ask her yourself." Marisette settled her hands in her lap. "I don't send a girl of mine to write that."

*

**

The third floor at Constantine's had both windows open and it was cold. It smelled of the river and of something green and bitter that had been boiled and left. There was a grey cat on the sill with its feet folded under it.

Emmeralda was at a writing table with her back to the window, in somebody's big wool coat over her shift. Her hair was off at the jaw. Hacked, not cut. Where the shift opened at the throat there was the top inch of a line, closed now, pink, and perfectly straight.

Gardwen sat on the boards beside the chair with her knees up.

There were eleven sheets on the table. Ten were spoiled, some after two words. She was four lines into the eleventh and she did not stop writing when Kag came in.

"Have you brought his comb?"

Kag put it down beside the inkwell.

Emmeralda stopped and looked at it. There was nothing on her head to put it in. She looked at it anyway, for longer than it took.

Then she pulled the coat closed at her throat with one hand and went back to the page.

“He’ll want to know I kept it hidden from Constantine.” The pen went into the ink. “That’s the part he’ll like.”

She turned the sheet a quarter so Kag could see what was on it.

“Tell me something I can write that only he knows.”

“I can’t help you there,” Kag said.

Emmeralda waited.

“If you want something off me it’ll be numbers of people crossing bridges, or what a house takes in a night off one room.” Kag turned her hands over. “You’re the only person alive who knows the man. I do need the letter soon. We’ve got the whole of it to set up.”

Emmeralda made a sound that was nearly a laugh, and it was the first one in that room in four days.

“Bridges,” she said. The pen was already moving. “All right, then.”

After that she wrote fast and did not stop, and the paper kept trying to lift in the draught until Gardwen got up without a word and pulled the far window down to a hand’s width.

Four lines. Six. She turned it over and did three more on the back.

“He told me I’d be out of this house inside a year, and I laughed at him.” She blotted it with the heel of her hand rather than wait for sand. “I’ve put that he was right. That I shouldn’t have laughed. That I can get out for an hour after the bell tonight and I’m frightened of Constantine.”

She folded it twice and pressed the crease flat with her thumbnail and held it out, and the coat fell open at the throat and she did not bother with it that time.

“Who’s carrying it?”

*
**

Kag asked who had carried the ones before.

"Ila," Emmeralda said. "Both times." The pen went down flat on the table. "And you're not having her."

The window Gardwen had left at a hand's width whistled. Gardwen was not looking at Emmeralda any more. She was looking at the door.

Ila was in it. Thirteen, elven, thin as a rope, barefoot on cold boards, holding a jug of water somebody had sent her for.

"I took the first one in a basket of his own shirts, back to the barge landing," Ila said. "The second I gave to the boy in the green coat at the Fishmarket end, because he'd started coming that way."

She looked at the folded paper in Kag's hand.

"He never looked at me once."

**

There was an argument after that and Kag did not win it and did not lose it either, and at the end of it Emmeralda came off the wall and took the comb out of Kag's hand before it got to the child.

She wrapped it in one of the spoiled sheets, folded the ends over the way you wrap a fish, and put it into Ila's palm with the letter on top of it and closed the girl's fingers on both.

"Don't wait for him to read it."

That was all of it. She went back to her chair and sat down, and she did that carefully too.

Ila had already put the bundle inside her shift.

CHAPTER 7 — THE LANDING



There were four thousand people on the slope at the Long Butts by noon and the wind was still coming across the range instead of along it, and that was all anybody talked about.

Kag did not hide. She got in among the nearest knot of people, who turned out to be taking bets, and complained about the wind, and inside a minute somebody had handed her a slate to hold because her hands were higher up than theirs.

The wide grey man on the stone below the black box read the crowd in slow sweeps, left to right, the way you read a page. His sweep came across and went over the top of her and kept going.

It put her forty feet off the box with her ear on the wrong side of a canvas screen.

*
**

The black box had six chairs and five of them were full. The Baron was on the left in a plain coat and was not watching the shooting. Santo was on the right, forward in the seat, elbows on the rail, watching it like a boy at a fair.

Out on the grass it came down to three.

The household's archer was good and shot into the crosswind the way a man shoots when he has been told what the shot is worth. The

elf in plain harness did not appear to allow for the wind at all. She put three in the middle at two hundred paces and the noise that went up off the slope was the loudest thing to happen in Purewater in a fortnight.

Then ninety seconds in front of the Governor's box with four thousand people waiting for it.

Temerach Nebulo took the wreath, said the eleven words the form wanted, and walked off the grass.

The slope did not know what to do with that and went on cheering.

Behind the canvas, while it was still going, Kag heard the grey man say a short thing to somebody, and the somebody said, "He'll not like it," and the grey man said:

"He doesn't leave the ship tonight. Tell the boatmen it comes from his father."

*
**

The horn went for the close of the day's shooting and four thousand people stood up and started to think about the water.

It happened the way Kag had said it would at dawn.

They came off the slope and the landing took about forty of them at a time. The boats were not ready and were never going to be ready. The household came down onto the stone with the rest of the city and stood in it. The Baron with two knights at his shoulder. Santo three feet from a fishmonger's wife. All of them waiting on Purewater boatmen who were in no hurry at all.

Ila went in from the bollard side with a basket of somebody's laundry on her hip, which she had not had an hour before.

She was good. She came up on his blind side and the bundle went from her hand to his without either of them looking down at it, and she was four people away before he had closed his fingers on it.

The wide grey man on the step above watched the whole of it.

He did not shout and he did not reach for Santo. He came down two steps into the crowd at walking pace and put his hand round the top of the girl's arm the way you take hold of a gate, and turned her to face him.

*
**

There were eleven people between Kag and them and most of them were trying to get to the same nine steps.

She got her shoulder into the back of the press and drove, and a landing full of people who have been standing still for twenty minutes does not move. It compacts. Two men went sideways into a fish crate. Somebody's hat went in the water. The whole mass shunted a foot and a half and stopped against itself.

Blau did not look up at the shove.

Kag went again, and the second time she got it right, because a boat had come alongside and the front of the crowd had started to move and she put her weight into the back of it at the moment it wanted to go anyway.

Forty people went forward at once. A woman two along from Blau lost the stone and went into the water between the hull and the steps with a shriek and a gout of green, and three men grabbed for her, and the whole landing turned into that instead.

Blau let go of the girl's arm to take the woman's wrist and hauled her out one-handed onto the stone like a man landing a net. He set her on her feet. He looked around for the child.

The child was not there any more.

He had her face, though. And he had had her for about eight seconds first.

Out on the water the household's boat was pulling for High Isle. Santo sat in the stern with one hand flat inside his coat, looking at the wake.

CHAPTER 8 — NINE STEPS



The Lily Garden's back water-stair was four feet of wet stone and nine steps down to a dead end, with a gate at the top you could lift off its pins with one hand.

Hesper's skiff was at the foot of it with a line out and a rod propped in it, and Hesper was a shape in a coat doing nothing at all.

Tess came down at the bell in Emmeralda's grey, sat on the fourth step with her back three-quarters to the gate, and stopped moving in a way that actual people cannot do.

Deri and Fen were on the stone at the top, one either side, forty feet apart, arguing about a horse.

Then it was the waiting, which is the part nobody writes down. The water slapped. Somebody two houses over was having the same argument they had had the night before. The wet line came up out of the dark from Hesper's hand to Kag's and she could feel the boat breathe on it.

Full dark. She could see all of it.

*
**

Twenty minutes past the bell a skiff came up the canal from the seaward end with no lamp on it, moving slow, and there were three people in it.

Two of them were poling, one fore and one aft, standing up and easy with it, which meant they were Purewater men, because nobody out of a country with roads stands up in a boat.

The third sat amidships with a cloak over his head.

At twenty feet the cloak came off, because he could not help wanting to see the steps.

Nineteen. Dark hair. A plain brown thing over something that had cost a great deal more, and one hand flat inside the front of it.

The man on the aft pole was Tam.

Tam, off the Guild landing, lifted at four in the morning three days before and not seen on that water since, standing up in a boat poling the Baron's son to a dead-end stair and looking back over his shoulder the whole way up the canal.

Kag pulled the line.

*
**

It came tight and somewhere below her in the dark Hesper said one word, not loudly, the way you say somebody's name across a room.

Tess went over sideways on the fourth step with her cheek on the stone. Out. Breathing.

Santo did not.

He stood there a second and a half looking at a girl who had just gone to sleep at his feet at the bottom of a dead-end stair, and then he ran, and he ran the wrong way. Down, at the water, because the top of the steps had two men on it and water had been the way out of everything his whole life.

Kag came down nine wet steps.

He got one foot onto the gunwale of Hesper's skiff and the skiff did what a skiff does under one foot, and then there was a forearm across his chest and that was the whole of it. Ten stone of nineteen-year-old in a very good coat. He kicked once and stopped.

The letter came out of the front of his coat with the comb still folded in the spoiled page.

Hesper had already sat back down and picked up the rod.

Six feet away, Tam stood in the other boat with the pole in his hands and his mouth open.

He had known Kag eleven years.

Kag winked at him over the top of Santo's head, and Tam shut his mouth and after a moment jerked his chin about a quarter of an inch and turned his face out to the canal like a man who has come out to look at the weather.

*
**

The room they had ready at the Mother of Pearl was off the landing with a stone floor and a drain in the middle of it, which is where they washed linen, and there was one chair carried in from somewhere.

Santo went into it hard enough that it moved.

Marisette came in behind and did not hurry and sat down on a stool by the wall and arranged her skirts as though it were any other evening in any other room in her house. Fen put a lamp on the floor. The light went up the walls.

Emmeralda walked the four doors herself.

She came down in the big coat with her hair off at the jaw and asked to be let in and Kag opened the door for her.

He heard the door and looked up expecting Marisette.

His whole face changed. He came forward against the cord as far as it let him and made a sound through the gag that had a shape to it and the shape was her name, and he did it three times. He thought the letter had worked.

Emmeralda stood in the doorway and looked at him with the lamp on him.

"Take that out of his mouth."

They took it out. He worked his jaw twice.

“Em.” His voice had not finished breaking. “I got your letter.”

Then he waited. He waited the way you wait for somebody to pass you something at a table.

She crossed the stone and stopped a yard in front of the chair.

“It wasn’t meant to be like that,” he said, low and quick, as though the two of them were alone and the rest were furniture he had not got round to. “You know it wasn’t.”

She went on looking at him.

“I can still take you out of here. Tonight. I’ve the boat.”

Emmeralda unfastened the coat.

She did not do it fast and she did not do it for effect. She opened it and held it open and stood there in a shift in a cold room, and the line he had put down her went from her collarbone to her hip, closed now, and pink, and perfectly straight, and there was a great deal of it.

He turned his head away.

She waited. He turned his head away again and she waited again, and the third time he looked, because there was nowhere in that room that was not her.

Then she closed the coat and held it shut at the throat with one hand the way she had all day and walked out past Kag.

She stopped in the doorway with her back to the room.

“He’s about five foot nine.”

*
**

Crowbill was in the back of an ice-house on the Shoals at two in the morning with a lamp and a blanket over his knees, because that was where he was at two in the morning.

He heard all of it. He did not ask a question until she had stopped.

“When Marisette has him in a chair, I want the asking,” he said. “The Baron on a boat and gone inside the week, and not one word said out loud about anybody’s face.”

A beat.

“And you’ll be the one who tells the two of them that. Not me.”

*
**

She told them. She told them the whole of it, and Marisette held her glass halfway up for about as long as it takes a cat to cross a room and then drank it.

“Eleven houses are going to ask me why we opened and nothing was said,” Marisette said. “And I shall have to let them think what they think.”

Emmeralda did not move off the wall through any of it.

Later, in the ice-house again, Kag gave Crowbill the other half.

“He’s not going to trade for that boy,” she said. “He’s got a champion and a city to take and one son he’s never once been seen to like, and if we hand the boy back the only thing we’ve bought is his attention. He’ll not pay. He’ll remember.”

“Then what.”

“Then Marisette gets her answers out of him, and then he’s fish food, and the twelve of us know he rode out of town with a girl — which two bridges of people watched happen on Tuesday night and every one of them believes, because Randall wore the coat and Tess wore the grey and nobody had to be told to lie about anything.”

Crowbill sat with it while the ice ticked.

“The run goes out over the bar at four every morning of the year with nobody watching it, because it’s ice,” he said at last. “But the pots are off the Lost Isle and the men who lift them are mine and they don’t look in.”

He trimmed the lamp without looking at it.

“And you’ll do it yourself. Not Deri. Not Fen. Not some fellow I’d have to pay and then worry about.”

He was entirely pleasant about it, the way he had been all week.

“Eleven people can carry a story about a boy who ran off. Twelve people cannot carry a murder. So it’s one pair of hands, and they’re yours.”

CHAPTER 9 — THE ICE RUN



He went down into the boat still in a girl's blue cloak with his feet bare, and he did not fight it, because it had not occurred to him yet that there was anything to fight.

Past the last of the Pearl the light came up grey off the water. The Lost Isle was a low green nothing with a fringe of poles in the shallows where the pots were set. Nobody lived on it. The men who lifted the pots came at nine.

He asked one question on the way over, about halfway.

"Is my father paying?"

She did not answer him, and after a while he stopped expecting one, and then he sat and watched the water go past the way anybody does.

It was quick and it was done from behind and he did not see it coming.

The rest of it was work. There was a gutting board on the stilt-shed that the pot-men used, and a knife on a lanyard, and a bucket. The pots went down full and heavy on the far string where the water ran deep and cold. The blue cloak went down with a stone in it somewhere else. The board got three buckets of seawater and a scrub with sand.

The tide turned while she was washing her arms.

*
**

By the time she was back on the Shoals the first thing she saw was a Dragon Knight on the Fishmarket steps trying to get a boatman to take him to High Isle, and not one of the six men there was looking up.

The streets had stopped working at first light and they had stopped working politely.

Nobody was rude to any of them. That was the thing about it. There was no ice. There was no bread off the Fishmarket. There was no boat at the Vantt landing and no boy to run a message and no rope when they wanted rope, and everybody was very, very sorry.

Four Knights rowed themselves to High Isle that morning in a hired boat with nobody to hire, and went round and round in the Lullwater for twenty minutes while the fish market watched, and one of them lost a pole.

Nobody laughed out loud. Everybody laughed for the rest of the week.

*
**

Temple Isle has no bridge to it, so half of Purewater was afloat that morning, gunwale to gunwale in a slow ring off the steps, families standing up in the boats and children on shoulders and somebody working the outside of the ring selling something hot out of a tub.

The Sacred Confluence came down off the temple in shallow terraces to a pool at the waterline and a broad stair of wet green stone. Nerissa's novices worked the running order with white rods and no deference to anybody. The houses went down by precedence, the head of each with his champion, stripped to the waist for the water, and were put under by a priestess who was not gentle about it.

The di Teufels were called near the end.

The Baron came down the green stone with his shirt off and there it was. A flat black chain, close to the throat, and something small on it under the hollow of his collarbone.

Behind him, bare-headed in the light for the second time in his life, came the boy who was too thin for the body he was in, and who walked like somebody being walked.

The stair packed solid behind them with forty people trying to see.

A body-length off the Baron's left shoulder, going down the steps with his head turned the other way, was Nus.

*

**

The priestess put the Baron under with a hand flat on the back of his neck and held him there a good deal longer than that man had been held anywhere in nine weeks.

He came up streaming. Somebody put a cloth in his hands. The whole stair closed in behind to get the boy in next, and for about four seconds there was nothing on those steps but wet backs and elbows.

Nus went past him on the step above, close as a man passing in a corridor, and his hand went across the Baron's throat and off again and he kept walking.

Nothing came away in his fist.

Nothing happened either. The Baron did not turn round. He had a cloth over his face and a boy had just had his fingers on the thing at his throat, and he was drying his eyes.

Kag was twenty-five metres off in a hired skiff and she was the only person on that water who had seen it, and she saw why.

There was no clasp on it. It was a closed ring, worn short and tight at the collarbone, and it had been on that man since before any of this started. It did not lift and it did not come over a head. It came off with a cut, or it did not come off.

Nus got to the top of the stair, turned, and found her across the water.

She shook her head once. That was the whole conversation.

Something went out of his shoulders and he turned and went up between the temple wall and the crowd and did not look back.

*
**

On the stair the priestess had the champion.

She put her hand flat on the back of the boy's neck the way she had done it forty times that morning and walked him down into the pool, and the water went over him.

And she took her hand off him early.

Not much. A count or two, where every other man on that stair had got the full measure and a bit more for being important. She stepped back off the bottom step with her skirts dragging and looked up the terraces at Nerissa and waited there to be told something.

Nerissa did not tell her anything. Nerissa said the words over the boy from where she stood, in the same voice she had used all morning, and the white rods moved the next house down.

The boy came up out of the Lady's water and stood there dripping and did not wipe his face and did not blink.

The Baron already had his shirt on.

*
**

The champion took the sand at noon and won it in under a minute.

He put a grown knight of the King's Assay down twice and then broke his leg in three places with the flat of the thing, and the crowd on the slope went quiet instead of loud, because it was not sport and everybody could tell. The helm never came off. The man he broke was alive and would never walk right.

Kag slept through it in the room over the Chandler's and woke in the middle of the afternoon to a boy sitting on the end of the bed with his feet not reaching the floor.

*
**

Gardwen went into the sea at dusk off the seaward rocks at High Isle and left her boots on a flat stone above the tideline, tied together at the tops, side by side, the way you leave them at a bathing place.

The ship lit up at nine. Lanterns on deck, four of them, then six. Men out along the pier with boat-hooks going down into the water by the mooring chains, and a light held over the side and walked the whole length of the hull twice. A voice giving orders. Not shouting.

They were at it the better part of half an hour and they never brought anything up.

Kag sat down out of the wind on the seaward side and watched a wolf.

It was a long time. The tide went all the way out and the rocks came up black and streaming. Nus fell asleep sitting up at midnight and woke with a jerk every ten minutes. The ship's lanterns went from six back down to two.

The wolf did not move for three hours.

Then, past two, she came off the high rock in four jumps and went into the shallows to her chest and stood facing out with her head low, and made a sound with her mouth shut.

Forty feet out, something changed shape on the water.

She came in on her side doing a stroke with one arm that was not a stroke any more, and the wolf went out to her and got a mouthful of her shirt and hauled, and Kag went in off the rocks to her thighs and took the rest.

She was cold past shivering. Her lips were grey-blue and her hands were dead white and the rocks had opened her up the length of one shin.

She could not talk for a while.

Then she got hold of Kag's collar with a hand that could not grip and said it straight into her face.

"He *begs*."

CHAPTER 10 — AN ITEMISED BILL



They got her warm on Constantine's wash-room floor with every blanket in the house and the firebox roaring, and Constantine did it slowly, the way you do it for men out of the Mouth in February, because she had seen what hot does to them.

Magda sat on the boards with Gardwen's head on her thigh and rubbed her hands between her own and said the whole time in a level voice that she was a bloody fool and would be up in an hour.

It took better than an hour before the shaking started, which Constantine said was the good sign.

Gardwen talked in pieces with her eyes shut.

She had got to the chains at the stern, under the counter, where the hull was warm because the galley flue ran down. The reinforcement went about a quarter of an hour. The Baron talked. Low and steady and kind, she said, and she used that word twice.

The thing that answered him was not a seventeen-year-old. It was a grown man's voice out of a boy's chest and it was asking to be let go. Not once. Over and over, the whole quarter of an hour, underneath everything else, the way a man asks for water.

"He calls him by his name. Cailan. He says it every night."

She had lost the last of it when the tide came up and she could not get her ear back on the planking. That was when she slipped and

the chain rang and the lanterns came out, and she went under the counter and stayed there in the cold for two hours with boat-hooks going past her.

“And after he’d gone.” Her mouth had trouble with it. “When it was just the water. Somebody in there was crying. A boy. Not the other one. A boy.”

Her eyes opened.

“He’s in there the whole time. He hears all of it.”

*
**

The wide grey man came ashore at half seven in the morning and went up and down the Fishmarket bridge asking after Kag by name, and he asked politely.

Kag went and met him. He was standing in the middle of the bridge at a fish stall with two Dragon Knights behind him and a purse in his hand, and nobody was serving him.

It was not a scene. The woman behind the trestle weighed whiting for a man on his left and then started on somebody else, and the queue rearranged itself around him the way water goes round a post. He had been there ten minutes. The most dangerous man on the island, and he could not buy a fish.

“I need to hire somebody in Purewater,” Blau said. “Nobody in Purewater will take my money.”

He turned his hands over, empty.

“You’re the first person in two days who’s walked toward me. What will it cost?”

*
**

It came out at six boats, tonight, after the closing, off High Isle’s seaward pier on the ebb, out through the Mouth and east along the coast. Twenty-two people and their gear. Cash on the stones before anything loaded.

“And there’s one more thing that comes with us,” Blau said. “It goes in the bottom of a boat, it doesn’t get opened, and nobody puts a hand on it but me.”

In eleven minutes of talking he never once said *my lord*, or *the Baron*, or *di Teufel*, or named anybody he worked for at all.

*
**

Kag found the man who was following her in about a minute.

He was two boats back and he had never done it before in his life. He changed ferries when she changed ferries. He got out at the Fishmarket steps and could not think of anything to do there, so he bought a fish he did not want and stood holding it.

It was Dess. Rope and cordage, third stall along, eleven shillings short on Monday because four of them had walked off with sixty feet of his best line.

She came up behind him on the steps and cleared her throat and he went four inches straight up and the fish went in the water.

“That was my dinner,” Dess said, and then shut his eyes.

It took ten seconds after that. A shilling a day and sixpence for anything written down. He was to say where she went and who she talked to and whether she went on the water at night. He gave it up so fast it was clear he had been sick about it since noon.

“There’s eight of us,” he said. “He hired eight off the bridge out of his own purse and he told every one of us not to tell the others.”

Kag took the slate off him and wrote it out for him in a hand better than his and worse than a clerk’s.

Went Pearl about 3. Sylph’s Embrace. Big argument with the woman Constantine out in the street, heard by all. Left angry. Fishmarket. Ate. Did not go on the water.

Nothing on it was a lie. That was the trick of it.

"Six o'clock," Dess said, patting his coat. "Under the third arch of the Gate of Triumph bridge, on the water. He doesn't come himself. There's a woman in a boat."

*
**

The woman in the boat was fifty-odd and built like the winch she sat next to, with cloth wound round her head and her boots off and a pipe that did not come out of her mouth for conversation.

Her name was Ossa Kyne and she saw Kag coming a long time before Kag got there, because she had spent thirty-five years looking at water for a living.

"No bucket tonight," she said. "So say it out loud or clear off."

Kag laughed at herself and asked if the woman knew her.

"Everybody on this water knows you. You're Crowbill's counting." Ossa thumbed the pipe down. "And you're the one that stood on the Fishmarket bridge on Monday and told four of the Baron's men to their faces they were thieves. My sister's boy was on that bridge. He's told it about nine hundred times and it gets better every time."

She did not do favours. She said so. Then she answered the question anyway, for her sister's boy.

"He's not looking for a man. Not once did he say a man, nor a body, nor a size, nor a night." She handed over a folded square of paper out of an oilcloth. "He's looking for a knife."

It was a drawing. A single blade near enough to life size, done in ink with a fine nib, barbed along the back, and a mark near the ricasso rendered with more care than the rest of it.

Underneath, in a small tidy hand: *any canal, any depth. Ten sovereigns. No questions asked or answered.*

"He gave one of those to every dredger on the water," Ossa said.

Ten sovereigns was more than that woman made in a season.

*
**

Kag had never lifted the knife. She had taken a rubbing off the floor and left the thing where it lay.

So it was still there. Four nights on, against the skirting on the third floor at the Sylph's, in a house the grey man had walked through that afternoon, with the blood gone from black and tacky to black and dry.

She took it out in a doubled linen off Constantine's press, tied at both ends with kitchen twine, and it went in the bottom of the pack under the bedroll and weighed nothing at all.

And Constantine had written that room up in her own house ledger on the night, standing up, in a clear round hand, and had told Kag to come back in daylight so she could countersign.

*
**

Temerach Nebulo was at the back corner table of the Moist Oyster with her back to the wall and a mail coat across her knees, going along the rings one at a time, while at the fire end Thorne told forty people about an elf who had put four arrows in the middle at two hundred paces that morning.

She put the tool down flat on the table, which from a woman who had not stopped for the whole of Thorne's story was a considerable amount of attention.

"Say the girl's name or don't, I don't need it yet. The scroll. How much of it is there, is it burnt, and how do you know the hand is his?"

Kag told her.

"Who saw it come out of the grate besides you."

Constantine. And it was in her house ledger, written that night, standing up.

"And the mark on the knife?"

Orsk & Daughter. Hild's book, chained to the bench, four generations. Cut to a stranger's drawing on the fourth of June, four months before the column came down the Anminster road.

Something happened behind the elf's face and was gone before it could be named.

"Where is the knife now?"

"We have it. Happy to hand it all over to you if you ask."

Temerach did not say yes.

"A Purewater thief walks into a tavern and offers a King's officer the one thing she has wanted for four years, for nothing at all." Her eyes came up. "What do you want?"

"I want the fucker gone. He's a scourge on this city and I resent his men strutting round like they own the place."

The elf nodded once, because it matched what three separate people had told her about Kag before supper.

"Good. That I can work with. A man who wants paying I have to think about."

*
**

In Hild's shed at seven in the morning the two women who kept the books established inside ninety seconds that they liked each other, and then they went at it like a stocktake.

Constantine described a clerk's hand. Hild described a callus. Temerach said almost nothing and wrote almost everything.

Then Hild put both hands flat on the bench and said no.

"I'll not swear a Baron bought it. A Baron didn't buy it. A Purewater man of about fifty-five bought it, with ink on his middle finger and the buttons cut off his coat so there'd be nothing on him to know him by, and he stood where you're stood and he was frightened the whole time."

She looked up.

"My great-grandfather started that book. Nobody has ever put a thing in it that wasn't so."

Temerach, who had not moved from the door, let out a breath that was almost certainly relief.

“Good. That’s the only kind of witness worth having.” And then: “Would you know him again?”

Hild went to the back of the shed and was gone a while and came back with a smaller book, unchained, the instrument book, and turned the pages with her thumb.

“I’ve made for him. Twice. A pair of calipers and a brass rule with a Guild stamp on the tang.” She turned it round. “I never knew him in the shed in June because he wasn’t in his coat. That’s why he cut the buttons off. It’s not the buttons. It’s the indigo.”

The page had a name on it and a Guild, and the date was two years old, and the hand was Hild’s own.

Ivo Calder. Tide Master, Watercrafters Guild. Assessor by appointment to the city of Purewater.

“That’s the man who signed off the Lady’s fouling as a false reading in the spring,” Constantine said, to nobody.

Kag stood at the back by the quench tub and let the honest people work.

*
**

The offer came back off the boy in the green cap at ten past twelve and Pell had it word-perfect because he had made him say it twice.

“He says: agreed, the whole of it, six hundred, cash on the stones at dusk.” A breath. “And he says one line’s wrong. *Twenty-one heads, not twenty-two.* And he says the item goes in the boat first, not last.”

Pell looked up.

“He didn’t say anything about the money at all.”

She had priced it on the floor of the counting room with her back to the wall and the book on her knee, and what came out of it was not a price. It was an invoice.

Six hulls at forty-five the boat, because a boat that goes out past the bar at night with armed strangers in it may not come back, so it is sold and not hired. Twelve polers at eight the man, per man. Passage, twenty-two heads, four the head — itemised, every head the same rate, servant, soldier and his lordship, and the line said so in words. One item carried in the bilge, not opened, at our risk. Short notice, night tide, no return cargo.

Six hundred.

Crowbill had read it standing up all the way to the bottom and then gone back to the third line and read that one again.

“If that man is going in a boat tonight, this comes back with nothing said about that line, because it’s four shillings and an insult and he’s not got time for either.”

He had looked up.

“And if it comes back corrected, we’ve got him.”

CHAPTER 11 — CROWBILL'S TOWN



Mariarta copied the invoice out in her own hand at Marisette's low table, a good round hand with no flourishes, every line in the same order. She copied the struck line too. *Twenty-two heads*, ruled through, and *twenty-one* written above it.

"A copy in my hand is better than the thing itself," she said. "If I had the original off your table you'd have missed it and come looking, and he'll know that. A woman who copied what she saw is a woman who couldn't take it."

She capped the ink and found the last hole herself.

"He'll ask why I brought it to him. And the answer is that his officers have run fourteen nights of credit at the Promise of Heaven and I have it all written down, and if that household goes east on a tide tonight I'm carrying the lot."

She folded it small.

"Captain Atarer has never been in a house on this island and never will be. He doesn't drink and he doesn't sit down." She looked up. "But I've been asked to the closing by two of his officers, and he'll be stood at the back of his own men on the north terrace. I've watched him stand there four days running."

*
**

High Isle's seaward pier at dusk was black stone, four boat-lengths long, a ship lying alongside with two lights, and the ebb already running.

Six boats came in out of the dark at ten past six and tied up.

Kag did not hide. She stood on the stones in the open with a lamp beside her, because she was the contractor and there was six hundred to be handed over before anything went in a boat.

They came off at twenty to seven, and they came off well. No shouting. Bundles first, then people, in ones and twos, down the plank and along the stones in a line that did not bunch.

Twenty-one of them. She counted.

Blau came down third and walked straight to her and counted six hundred into her hands in coin, on the stones, in front of his own people, and did not hurry it and did not ask her to count it after.

"Boats look right," he said.

The last thing off that ship came up out of the hold on ropes. A chest, near seven feet, rope beackets on both ends. It took four of them and they struggled with it and it was far heavier than a chest that size. It did not shift inside and it made no sound at all. The underside was wet and steaming in the cold, because it had spent its life below a waterline.

Blau put both hands on it going down the plank and did not take them off until it was in the bilge of the second boat.

Kag's boat. Kag's man on the rope.

*
**

The skiff went off the end of the pier like a man ferrying a message about boats. Four minutes across the point. A girl with a tray crossing a slope in the dark. A cup offered at an elbow.

They loaded well. Bundles down, people after, weight spread, a man of hers in each stern saying *further forward* and *sit down* in the voice you use on people who do not know boats.

The ebb was going hard. Seven o'clock came and went.

Five boats loaded. The sixth took the last four and their gear, and that was twenty-one.

There was nothing at all on the path up from the terraces.

"Right," Blau said, not loudly, to the whole pier. "Cast off."

Kag put her head up and walked back along the stones with her hand raised, the way a man does when he has heard something over water.

"You've been paid," Blau said. "You want me on these stones another ten minutes and I've no idea why, and I'd rather not find out on a falling tide."

And then everybody else on the pier heard it too.

Boots on stone, up on the path — one man, running, and running the way a man runs when he is not thinking about the ground.

Baron Hanzo di Teufel came off the path at a dead run in the clothes he had stood in front of a Prince in an hour before. No harness. No sword. No household. One shoe gone somewhere. He was fifty-one and he had run the better part of a mile.

He stopped dead at the head of the line of boats.

He was not looking at Blau. He was looking at the second boat and the wet black chest in the bottom of it.

*
**

"Take it out of the boat," he said. His voice was wrecked from the running and it was not loud. "Put it back aboard and I will not have heard any of this."

"No, my lord."

"You'd never have got him home. You've been telling him he was going home for ten years and the boy believes it and you don't."

Blau got out of the boat and put himself between the Baron and the second boat and put a hand flat on his chest, and Hanzo walked into it and stopped.

Twenty-one people in five boats did not move, and not one of them said a word, because they were his household and he was still their Baron and none of them had worked out yet which way it went.

Then Hanzo looked past Blau's shoulder at the chest lying in the bilge with the water running under it, and he said a name.

Not loudly. Low and steady and kind, the voice you use on a horse, and it carried the whole length of that pier because everything else on it had gone silent.

"Thuban."

The chest moved.

Once. A single heavy shift, and the boat under it dipped and came back and the water slapped along the stones, and both of Crowbill's men in that boat were holding their poles badly.

He said it again and added three words in a language that put the hair up on her arms.

Something inside seven feet of wet oak took hold of the lid from underneath.

*

**

Kag went round the outside of the lamps with the cutter in her left hand and the thumb loop on.

His eyes came off the chest and went over her once and went straight back to the boat. A dock half-orc moving on a dock. He had not got room in his head that night for whatever she was, and he never had had, and it was the first time in her life it was worth anything.

She took three steps and was on him.

Left hand inside the open collar. Her fingers got under the ring — there was the slack, half a finger's worth where nine weeks of this city

had taken the flesh off him — and she hauled it up off the skin and held it there, and he came back against her like a sack.

The tongue went under. Steel between iron and throat.

One. Two. Three.

The ring did not part.

What it did was bite. There was a bright notch cut in the black iron the width of a fingernail, silver in the lamplight, and the wheel sat in the bottom of it and the ring was still a ring.

Men have stood there sawing at a thing for a minute and a half and been killed doing it.

Down the pier, Blau turned round. In the second boat the lid of the chest lifted three inches and stopped, held from underneath.

And the Baron of Teufel, hanging off her left hand with his wind-pipe half shut, got both arms up in front of him and started to say something that was not in any language spoken on that water.

She tried to put her head into the back of his skull and could not get it past her own arm.

He got the words out.

*
**

Everything stopped except her eyes and her ears.

Her left fist was inside his collar with the ring hauled up off his throat and her right thumb was through the loop with the wheel in its notch, and that was where they were, and they were not going anywhere, and neither was she.

Out on the black water somebody said one quiet word and nothing happened to him at all. He did not even turn his head towards it.

And then four crossbows went off out of the dark at about nine feet, because the standing order had been *not unless a man starts casting, and then until he stops*.

Two of them found him and both found the same place.

Baron Hanzo di Teufel stopped being a man mid-word. He went down instantly and completely, straight down, and he did not fall away from her, because her fist was still shut in his collar. He hung off her frozen arm with his whole weight on her knuckles and his chin on her wrist.

The ring was six inches under her eyes with one bright notch in it.

She could not turn the wheel. She could not let go. She could not say a word.

*
**

The skiff came in out of the dark on the seaward side without a lamp, close enough that the ship's lights picked it up, and a figure in a plain coat stood up in the stern in front of twenty-one people, Blau, six boat crews and whatever was standing on the stones in a wet shift.

Three words, and a hand cut sideways through the air.

It went out of her all at once and it was horrible, and she and the Baron went down onto the wet stone together in a heap with her fist still shut in his collar.

She got a knee under her.

Three turns. On the third the wheel went through and the notch became a gap, and the ring sprang — it sprang, like a thing that had been under tension for ten years — and the two cut ends jumped apart under her thumb and it came off the dead man's throat into her left hand.

There was a locket on it the size of a thumbnail. It was warm. It was much warmer than anything on that pier.

Above her the thing standing in the wet shift made a sound. Not a cry and not a word. Something going out of a chest, all of it, the way a man breathes out at the end of a very long day, and it went on longer than any lungs that size should hold.

Then the grown man's voice said one thing, and it was not to the pier and not to the dead man and not to anybody who had ever been afraid of it.

"Hold him. He'll not know how to stand."

The boy folded.

She got an arm up and took about half of him and he came down onto the stones across her knees, seventeen years old and eight stone of nothing, and his eyes were open and moving and he was looking at the lamps and the boats and the sky like somebody who had never seen any of it.

He made a noise. It was a boy's noise.

And behind her on the stones Gardwen came apart entirely, and Magda let her go, and she got there on her hands and knees.

*
**

Nobody in the boats had drawn a blade. There was not a single sword out on that water.

Twenty-one people sat in five boats with every possession they owned under the thwarts, on a running ebb, forty feet out from a pier, and the poles were in Purewater hands and not one of them could crew anything.

Two were standing. One of those was being sick over the side. An older man in the third boat had taken his hat off, which nobody had told him to do.

Blau came down the pier. He was not looking at his Baron and he was not looking at the boy.

"That," he said, "is mine."

"Since when."

"Since he was forty-four and I was nineteen." He did not move. "I have watched that man seat a spirit in a living body eleven times and

I have carried that locket in my own hand while he slept. There is not another person on this earth who knows what you are holding.”

A beat.

“And you are going to need to know, tonight, because that boy is not finished.”

*

**

He put his hands behind his back to be tied, which was the last unnerving thing he did.

“He was in that boy ten years. A seat that deep is a hole cut in a person, and it does not close because the tenant walked out of it, and there is a step my lord did every single morning of those ten years to keep the edges of it from working loose.”

The ebb ran along the stones.

“Nobody is going to do that tomorrow morning. Or the morning after. That is the free part, because you’d have found it out yourself by Thursday and by Thursday would be too late.”

For the rest of it — what the thing on the chain was, what it did to whoever carried it, what had to be done to the boy before the fourth morning — he wanted one boat, one man on the pole, and the sea.

“And I don’t want the locket. You’d not give it me and I’ve stopped wanting things I can’t have.”

*

**

She said the other thing loud enough for five boats and it carried a long way on water.

Nobody argued with any of it. The older man in the third boat put his hat back on.

Then Crowbill’s men leaned on the poles, because they had been paid six hundred in coin on those stones to take twenty-one people east on the ebb, and Crowbill’s people do what Crowbill said.

The five boats went out past the pier head into the black and the sound of them went with them, and inside two minutes High Isle's seaward pier was as quiet as it had been at six o'clock.

*
**

They brought him wrapped in a boat sail and he weighed almost nothing, which was the last thing she learned about Hanzo di Teufel.

Crowbill came down to the water himself, which he had not done once all week. He looked at the sail and at the man tied in the bottom of the boat and at the black ring lying open in her palm with the small warm thing on it and at a seventeen-year-old asleep against his sister with Magda's coat over him.

"Right," he said.

The body went in the ice-house on the stone under sacking, because the run goes out over the bar at four every morning of the year, and both of them would leave the city the same way inside two days and neither would ever be found.

He took the six hundred off her, counted it, and put two of every five back in her hands without comment, which was not a thing he had ever done in front of witnesses.

Then he stopped at the top of the steps.

"They heard you on that pier. Twenty-six people, and five of them were mine, and mine will tell it."

He almost smiled.

"Go and sleep, Kag. You're going to be hearing that one back off strangers by Friday."